NATIONAL ASSEMBLY 7TH PARLIAMENT

PARLIAMENTARY STANDING COMMITTEE ON ECONOMICS AND PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

REPORT OF THE 2024 PARLIAMENTARY GLOBAL FORUM HELD IN WASHINGTON D.C, USA

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ACRONOMYS AND ABBREVIATIONS

GPF	GLOBAL PARLIAMENTARY FORUM
WBG	WORLD BANK GROUP
IMF	INTERNATIONAL MONETARY FUND
AI	ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE
IMFC	INTERNATIONAL MONETARY AND FINANCIAL COMMITTEE
DC	DEVELOPMENT COMMITTEE
IDA	INTERNATIONAL DEVELOPMENT ASSOCIATION
PRGT	IMF'S POVERTY REDUCTION AND GROWTH TRUST
PN	PARLIAMENTARY NETWORK OF THE WORLD BANK AND INTERNATIONAL MONETARY FUND
RST	RESILIENCE AND SUSTAINABILITY TRUST
PRGT	POVERTY REDUCTION AND GROWTH TRUST
SDG'S	SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS

1. INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND

The 2024 Global Parliamentary Forum (GPF), took place from 15 to 16 April 2024 in Washington D.C, USA, ahead of the Spring Meetings that took place from 17 to 20 April 2024. The Forum was co-organized by the World Bank Group (WBG), the International Monetary Fund (IMF), and the Parliamentary Network on the World Bank and International Monetary Fund (PN).

The Parliamentary Network of the World Bank and International Monetary Fund (PN) was established in 2000. The network serves as a platform for Parliamentarians from Member countries to enrich their knowledge and experiences on accountability, transparency and empowers Parliamentarians to share knowledge and experiences through collective understanding of the global challenges. The network further serves as a platform for Parliamentarians to learn best practices in addressing the challenges, holding Governments and International Financial Institutions accountable and also shaping the international development agenda through discussions and policy decisions.

The Spring meetings of IMF and WBG are annual meetings that brings together Finance Ministers, Central Bank Governors, Development Experts, Private Sector Executives, Civil Society Representatives, Parliamentarians and Academics to discuss global economic and development issues. In addition, meetings for the Board of Governors, Development Committee (DC), and the International Monetary and Financial Committee (IMFC) also takes place during this time. The meetings play an important role in shaping the global economics discussions and findings solutions to major development challenges.

This year's session brought together Parliamentarians, Civil Society Organisations, Journalists, Private Sector Executive, Academics and Representatives of other International Organisation from around the world alongside senior officials from the World bank and IMF to share knowledge and best practices in development.

The year's theme "Multiple Global Challenges: Action for Impact" focused on the storm and challenges that are placing prosperity out of reach for millions around the world. Among topics discussed includes; Artificial Intelligence (AI), Climate solutions in a fragile world, Debt and Growth, International Development Association (IDA), Accountability and Governance and effective implementation of Gender Strategies.

The session concluded with the launch of the new Women MP Chapter of the Parliamentary Network and the fifth meeting of the Global Young MP initiative titled "Planting Seeds of Growth: creating green jobs for young people and the planet.

This report gives a summary of keys aspects that was discussed at the session.

2. PARTICIPANTS

The session was attended by Parliamentarians, Civil Society Organisations, Journalists, Private Sector Executive, Academics and Representatives of International Organisation from 78 countries around the world.

National Assembly was represented by Members of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Economics and Public Administration namely; Honourables: Natangue Ithete (Chairperson), Bertha Dinyando and Kennedy Shekupakela. The Honourable Members were accompanied by Ms Theresia Dimba, Parliamentary Clerk.

Honourables; Natangue Paulus Ithete, Kennedy Hiskia Shekupakela and Bertha Dinyando at the World bank headquarters, Washington.

3. MEETINGS PROCEEDING

3.1 WELCOMING SESSION

The session was officially opened on 15 April 2024 by the Rt Hon. Liam Byrne MP, Chair of Business and Trade Committee in UK, and Chairperson of the Parliamentary Network on the World bank and IMF. The Chairperson welcomed all participants and mentioned that the session was being held during one of the biggest years of elections, where about 4 billion people around the world will go to the polls and that the elections will necessitate big discussions and policies decisions over the years ahead.

In his opening remarks the Chairperson informed the participates regarding the election of the new board members of the Parliamentary Network on the World bank and IMF that concluded end of 2023 and introduced the newly elected board members.

During the years the network worked on fostering communication, training and building relationship with parliaments. With regards to communication, the network created new chapters and podcast around the world to foster communication.

The network also introduced innovative ways to build relationships between the World Bank and IMF together with Parliamentarians, Civil Society Organisations, Journalists, Private Sector Executive, Academics and Representatives of other International Organisation.

In terms of training, the network has a new McGill University program targeting new and young Parliamentarians to pursue a Professional Development Certificate in Parliamentary Governance to better perform their parliamentary duties and serve the citizens. Participants were introduced to some of the 28 McGill University program graduates that graduated recently.

In his remarks, the chairperson further mentioned the seven (7) giant blocking the path of achieving the sustainable development goals, namely; poverty, hungry, disease, conflicts, debts, education and climate change. He stated that these giants are getting bigger and the only way to address the challenges is for the participants to find better ways to share prices and guard each other against the giants along the way.

He also mentioned that the international financial institutions that was created in 1944 is amongst the most important force to help address the challenges of the seven giants. Over the last years financial Institutions have transform their mission, model and money but they are only at the beginning of building the new foundations for the new times. There is still huge debate on representation, rules to be made on debts and taxes and issues of resources.

According to the Chairperson, UN requires an increase in the multilateral lending amount between 500 billion to 1 trillion. This are some of the biggest tasks that the network has to perform but the network cannot perform this task alone without the assistance of the Parliamentarians, Civil Society Organisations, Journalists, Private Sector Executive, Academics and Representatives of other International Organisation.

The Chairperson highlighted three points in which the network can work closely with the Parliamentarians, Civil Society Organisations, Journalists, Private Sector Executive, Academics and Representatives of other International Organisations namely;

a) Crafting programmes that works for member countries,
b) Ensuring that the voices of Parliamentarians, Civil Society Organisations, Journalists, Private Sector Executive, Academics and Representatives of other International Organisations are heard in some of the biggest debates,
c) Making sure Parliamentarians, Civil Society Organisations, Journalists, Private Sector Executive, Academics and Representatives of other International Organisations attend big events.

The Chairperson alluded that it is important that participant's voices are heard in the reform debate and were urged to participate in some of the key events such as:

- The spring meetings
- The UN Summit of the future which will be held end September 2024
- The Annual Meeting in October 2024
- The IDA 21st replenishing pledging session that will be held in December 2024. Every three years, the IDA calls on its donors to replenish its funds so that the association continue making an impact. This year marks IDA's 21st replenishment round (IDA21) since 1960. In December, donors will pledge their contributions for the next three years. The pledging session will bring together richer donor countries to mobilised 100 billion dollars for development. The event will be the first big opportunity for the network to build a new foundation and increase IDA's resources.

3.2 STATEMENT BY HON. MARLENE MALAHOO FORTE MP, AND MINISTER OF LEGAL AND CONSTITUTIONAL AFFAIRS, JAMAICA, VICE CHAIRPERSON OF THE PARLIAMENTARY NETWORK ON THE WORLD BANK AND IMF

The vice- chairperson commended IMF and the World bank for organising the session and called on the Parliamentarians as representative of citizens to make a positive difference during the two days meeting.

She mentioned that as representative of the people with common goals and issues, language should not be a barrier. Whether elected or appointed Members, there was a need to understand how decision are made, how money is spent and how priorities are decided, thus the important of the session.

The Chairperson further explained the importance of the network, what the network has been doing and planned to do and called on the participants help shape the International agenda.

Participants were given the opportunity to indicate topics to be discussed during the course of the week and were requested to assist the board members in crafting a plan for the year that will help sharpened programmes for the future.

3.3 MEETING WITH THE WORLD BANK PRESIDENT AND IMF MANAGING DIRECTOR

The town hall meeting was officially opened by the Rt. Hon. Liam Byrne, Chairperson of the Parliamentary Network on the World bank and IMF. The closed door session provided the participants an opportunity to engage the World Bank President, Mr Ajay Banga and IMF Managing Director Ms Kristalina Georgieva. The meeting discussion were around the Global crises and Geo Politics.

The World bank president emphasised the important of understanding the intertwining challenges the world is facing namely; the SDG's, employment gap among the youth and the need to find ways for World bank to address the issues and build an impact.

The World bank president further mentions that for the current spring meetings the banks will focus in two topics namely; access to energy and power in Africa and better health care across the world.

Ms Kristalina Georgieva, IMF Managing Director mentioned two challenges facing the world; unexpected shocks such as climate change and pandemic etc. heating the world especially the most vulnerable people and countries (low income countries) and the slow growth in the world's economy, although stable but not growing as anticipated.

She further mentioned that there is low productivity and growth and also an increase in the inflation rate projected across the world for the next five years and the mostly affected will be the low income countries.

According to the IMF Managing Director, majority of the countries have exhausted their capacity to respond to the unexpected shocks such as climate change and there is a need to rebuild the physical capacity to handle these shocks. However, according to the projection, it will be difficult to rebuild the capacity especially this year where half of the world is having elections.

The IMF fund has a huge obligation to provide its member countries with the following; specific country fiscal projection and advise, bringing price stability to revitalised growth and advise on medium term fiscal framework that are not suffocating such as investing in what can lift up productivity, human capital, critical infrastructure and climate resilience.

The IMF Managing Director mentioned that over the years, the IMF fund had injected 1 trillion dollars in reserve and liquidity, has reformed the financial capacity, increase the quotes to 50 %, and reforming the lending instruments for low incoming countries and climate crisis.

The World Bank President and IMF Managing Director informed the participates regarding the different reforms they plan to implement to address global crisis and to ensure that the bank and fund is resilient and sustainable.

Ms Kristalina Georgieva was congratulated for being reappoint as the Managing Director of IMF for a second five years' term.

3.4 OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES OF ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE: A CALL FOR GLOBAL LEGISLATIVE GOVERNANCE

The session included a panel of discussion and presentations. The discussions were around the opportunities and challenges of Artificial Intelligence (AI). Although the potential transformation of Artificial Intelligence (AI) across sectors such as manufacturing, finance and health promises increased productivity and reshaped work landscapes. However, there is inherent risks which demands proactive mitigations through robust global legislative framework so that countries can ensure that AI remains an equitable and valuable tool serving everyone.

Participants deliberated on issues such as AI preparedness, inequality effects, digital infrastructure, issues of copyrights and privacy, capacity building, partnership for digital knowledge and sharing, issues of lack of data, gender base violence, misinformation, risk of widening bias, regulation and ethics, impact of AI on productivity and risk of AI on lower and high developed countries.

3.5 ACCELERATING CLIMATE SOLUTION IN A FRAGILE WORLD

The session served as a platform for participates to discussed issues of climate change and how it affects the world especially the most fragile and low-income developing countries. Responding to escalating climate threats in a fragile and low-income developing countries demands a complex globalized approach. While financing mechanisms like the IMF's Resilience and Sustainability Trust (RST) are crucial, maximizing their effectiveness is centred around several key elements.

Participants called on the Global Institutions to strategically prioritize and focus their efforts, aligning resources to the most pressing needs. Participants further emphasised the need for robust accountability mechanisms to ensure transparency, efficiency and measurable progress towards climate goals.

The session further emphasised the importance of effective partnership with legislator to navigate the complex regulatory landscape and securing sustained political commitment. Participates were of the opinion that by adopting this principle, legislator together with RST and World bank can collectively accelerate the implementation of climate solutions and safeguard the vulnerable populations.

3.6 DEBT AND GROWTH: INVESTING IN THE INTERNATIONAL DEVELOPMENT ASSOCIATION AND THE POVERTY REDUCTION AND GROWTH TRUST

The session included a panel of discussion and presentation. Among topics discussed was the impact of rising debt on development progress, strategies for debt alleviation and sustainable debt management and advocated for replenishing of PRGT and IDA to secure their critical role in creating a future where development thrives, rather than succumbing to debt.

Participants had discussions on the issues of rising debts levels in low-income developing countries threatening economic development progress, crises such as pandemic and multiplying conflicts combined with inflation and slowed economic growth that have strained public finances in developing countries pushing more nations towards debt distress.

The session also emphasised the importance of tools such as the IMF's Poverty Reduction and Growth Trust (PRGT) and the International Development Association (IDA) in the management of debt.

3.7 ENHANCING ACCOUNTABILITY AND GOVERNANCE FOR BETTER DEVELOPMENT RESULTS: THE ROLE OF PARLIAMENTARIANS

As legislators, parliamentarians can play a key role in unlocking the power of accountability for sustainable development and economic growth.

The session mainly deliberated on the role of parliamentarians with regards to collaboration with the World bank and IMF on issues such as to reduce poverty, improve economic growth and development effectiveness and supporting the local actors and institutions for stronger accountability, and implement effective governance strategies to reduce poverty and improve economic growth.

3.8 CHAMPIONING EQUALITY: EMPOWERING MPS TO IMPLEMENT EFFECTIVE GENDER STRATEGIES

Among topics discussed is the global crises impacting women and girls, policy change to close the gender gap, how parliamentarians can influence effective gender strategies to advance gender equality for strong, sustainable and inclusive growth, the pressing need for gender equality in the face of global challenges and how MPs can utilize World Bank and IMF strategies to promote gender equality and empowered women.

The session concluded with the launch of a new Women MP Chapter of the Parliamentary Network. A platform for collaboration and action for women.

3.9 CONCLUDING REMARKS

The two days' session was official closed by the Rt Hon. Liam Byrne MP, Chairperson of the Parliamentary Network on the World bank and IMF. During his concluding remarks, the Chairperson called on the Parliamentarians to create platform within parliament. A platform for collaboration between Parliament, the World Bank and IMF. Participated were also urged to share agendas, thoughts and reflections of the week's spring meetings, to apply for the field visits that will take place in the Caribbean focusing on small states, to join the global chapters such as the newly launch Women Empowerment Chapter and other chapters they plan to launch such as the Chapter on Green Finance, AI and the Young people in the future.

The Chairperson thanked the organisers and participates for attending the session and called on the Parliamentarians to work together with courage and solidarity to ensure that they eliminate the difficult and complicated global challenges facing the world.

3.10 AFRICA GROUP 1 (AFG1) CONSTITUENCY MEETING

The delegation attended the Africa Group 1 (AfG1) Constituency Meeting together with Hon. Ipumbu Shiimi, Minister of Finance and Public Enterprises which took place on the 17 April 2024. The meeting was reserved for Minister of Finance and Governors of Central Bank from the African countries. The meeting was chaired by Hon. Ipumbu Shiimi in his capacity as the chairman of the African Group 1. Among topic discussed was a presentation of the Executive Director's Interim Report, a statement for African Group 1 Constituency, an update on the implementation of the Rotation System for Recruitment of the Office of the Executive Director (EOD) Advisors and an update on the 3rd chair for Sub-Saharan Africa (SSA).

4. CONCLUSION

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Economics and Public Administration would like extend its profound gratitude to the Honourable Speaker and the entire management and staff of the National Assembly for being accorded with the unique opportunity to attend the aforesaid Session in Washington D.C.

5. RECOMMENDATION

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Economics and Public Administration Recommends that the National Assembly consider and adopts this report;

5.1 That the National Assembly establish membership with the Parliamentary Network on the World Bank and the IMF through a Namibian Chapter; to be formed as an international parliament organisation of the National Assembly of Namibia.

5.2 That the National Assembly create a platform for Women Parliamentarians to participate in the Women MP Chapter of the Parliamentary Network, a platform for collaboration and action that empowers women and avail financial resources for women Parliamentarians to attend the sessions on an annual basis.

5.3 That the National Assembly in collaboration with the Parliamentary Network on the World Bank and IMF create a platform for Members of Parliament to participate in future planned chapters such as the Green Finance, Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Young people in the future.

5.4 That the National Assembly in collaboration with the Parliamentary Network on the World Bank and the IMF afford the opportunity to the new and young Parliamentarians to pursue the Professional Developments Certificate in Parliamentary Governance being offered by the McGill University to capacitate them in performing their parliamentary duties and serve the citizens better.

5.5 That the National Assembly create a platform for collaboration between Parliament, the World Bank and IMF.

5.6 That the Ministry of Finance and Public Enterprises provide support and collaborate with the National Assembly and the Standing Committee on Economics and Public Administration.

6. SIGNATURE

Hon. Natangue Ithete (Chairperson)	13/02/2025 **Date**
Hon. Mathias Mbundu (Deputy Chairperson)	
Hon. Marina Kandumbu	
Hon. Dr. Tobie Aupindi	
Hon. Apius !Auchab	
Hon. Bertha Dinyando	
Hon. Elifas Dingara	
Hon. Maria Elago	
Hon. Reginald Diergaardt	
Hon. Hamunyera Hambyuka	
Hon. Gotthard Kasuto	
Hon. Maria Kamutali	
Hon. Johanna Kandjimi	
Hon. Joseph Kauandenge	
Hon. Sebastiaan Karupu	
Hon. Daniel Kashikola	
Hon. Hilaria Mukapuli	
Hon. Jennifer Van Der Heever	
Hon. Fenni Nanyeni	
Hon. Kennedy Shekupakela	
Hon. Nico Smit	
Hon. Yvette Araes	